

《不上锁的人》or *Those Who Leave the Door Unlocked*

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Publication Date: April 2025

Excerpt from 《文康乐舞》or “Recreational Dancing”

冬天真的来了，人们终于又可以在兰桂坊庆祝万圣节了。那条熟悉的小斜坡上人头攒动，大部分人都都不戴口罩了，而是戴上蜘蛛侠、钢铁侠、小丑或者V字仇杀队的面罩，或以浓妆遮面，一簇簇鬼佬肩并着肩，唱着异域的歌曲。人们手舞足蹈，手上或是酒精或是烟草，各色脸孔上下翻动，像极了狂热球迷的波兹南舞。年轻的彩色身影如剪纸一样四处拼贴，而COA酒吧门口的石阶上还是坐满了各色的人，有穿羽绒服的，有穿泳装的，人手一杯梅斯卡尔，等待着永远无法入席的卡座。另一边是一个足球吧，几台大电视放着欧冠的直播画面，曼城对塞维利亚，底下是簇拥在一起的足球信徒们，手里都拿着啤酒。

*Winter had truly arrived, and people could finally celebrate Halloween in Lan Kwai Fong once more. The familiar little slope was packed with people; most no longer wearing face masks but instead donning Spider-Man, Iron Man, Joker, or V for Vendetta masks, others concealing their faces with heavy makeup. Clusters of foreigners stood shoulder to shoulder, singing songs from distant lands. People swayed and danced wildly, clutching either alcohol or tobacco. Faces of every hue bobbed up and down, reminiscent of the Poznan dance performed by soccer fanatics. Young, colorful silhouettes were scattered about like paper cutouts. The stone steps outside COA Bar remained packed with a motley crowd—some bundled in down jackets, others in swimwear—holding glasses of mezcal, waiting for a booth that would never be theirs. Across the street, a soccer bar broadcasted the Champions League live on several large screens—Manchester City versus Sevilla. Below, clusters of soccer fans huddled together, beers in hand.*

Translator notes:

Had a great deal of trouble deciding whether to write in present or past tense. In Mandarin Chinese, there are no tenses and the excerpt has no indicators of relative time, other than being part of a larger short story set in a Hong Kong emerging fresh out of quarantine. The differences in syntactic structure between Chinese and English are, as always, interesting to navigate. In the original text, there are numerous clauses—up to six in one sentence—that are separated by commas. In English, this would read like a list or a run-on sentence, but in Chinese, it gives the sensory details cadence and flow. This is Venuti’s “illusion of transparency [a]s an effect of fluent discourse... conceal[ing] the numerous conditions under which the translation was made” (1).

Perhaps most challenging and imperative to get across was the sort of warm and hopeful liveliness of the original text. The larger text is narrated by a young Hong Kong documentary student looking for material, and it later goes on to talk about the heartbreaking death of her father during the pandemic. However, this passage has a sanguine buoyancy to it, especially evident in phrases like “could celebrate Halloween in Lan Kwai Fong once more.” This is what happens in the “kinship” or meeting of two languages, and the shared meaning that extends beyond any one or two languages (Benjamin, 300; Appiah, 817). The feeling of being able to celebrate with friends and family again post-quarantine; that feeling exists in the kinship of every language-speaker who experienced the pandemic. In the words of Appiah, this is what the reading “is supposed to give a correct account of” (817).